

Official Curtis Riggleman

THE ROAD TO THE SALE

BOOK SIX

— • —
Curtis Riggleman



The Road To The Sale

©2026 Curtis Riggleman
www.officialcurtisriggleman.com

Curtis Riggleman is hereby identified as the author of this work in accordance with section 77 of the Copyright, Designs, and Patents Act 1988.

All rights reserved. No part of this work covered by the copyright herein may be reproduced or used in any form or by any means-- graphic, electronic, or mechanical, including photocopying, recording, taping, web distribution or information storage and retrieval systems-- without the prior written permission of the author.

ISBN: 978-1-969837-12-8 (Paperback edition)
ISBN: 978-1-969837-13-5 (eBook)

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication date
A catalog record of this book is available from the Library of Congress.

The purpose of this book is to provide the reader with general information about the subject matter presented. This book is not intended, nor should the user consider it, to be legal advice for a specific situation.

The author, company and publisher make no representations or warranties with respect to the accuracy, fitness, completeness, or applicability of the contents of this book. The author, company and publisher shall in no event be held liable for any loss or other damages, including but not limited to special, incidental, consequential, or other damages. Please consider carefully any advice the author gives before applying it in your workplace.

Cover design: Lyn Meredith
Design: Lyn Meredith
www.lynmeredith.com

The Road To The Sale

Curtis Riggleman

Official Curtis Riggleman

Introduction

WHAT YOU WILL LEARN IN THIS BOOK:

Selling a car isn't one skill. It is ten distinct moves, stacked in a specific order, and each one exists for a reason. The reasons are rooted in psychology- how people actually think and feel when they are about to make a big purchase.

Newer salespeople often make the mistake of treating the sale like a checklist that they can reorder, or skip around on. Skip the walkaround because the customer “already knows the car.” Skip the demo drive because the customer “isn't really that interested.” Rush the greeting because there is a line of customers waiting.

Every one of these shortcuts costs you. Sometimes it costs you rapport. Sometimes it costs you the entire deal. And almost always, it costs you gross profit.

Over this course, we are going to walk through all ten steps exactly as I use them on the floor. As we move through the steps, I want you thinking about sequence, how each step sets up the one that follows.

Table of Contents

01. Cultivate A Winning Attitude.....	9
02. The Power Meet & Greet.....	15
03.Intro: Setup To Make Money	21
04. Vehicle Selection & Presentation	35
05. Displaying The Vehicle	39
06. Selling The Walkaround	43
07. The Demo Drive.....	49
08. Building Rapport On The Drive.....	55
09. Committing to Come Inside....	59
10. The Write Up & The Close.....	65
11. Summary.....	69

STEP 1

Cultivate A Winning Attitude

Every sale I've ever closed started before I said a single word to the customer. It started with what I brought to the floor; my attitude. In this chapter, I want to break down exactly what that means, not as a vague motivational idea, but as a specific, repeatable mindset with three distinct layers.

Get this right, and every step that follows in this program becomes easier. Get it wrong, and no technique I teach you later will save the deal.

THE FIRST LAYER: GENUINE POSITIVITY

This isn't about faking enthusiasm or plastering on a smile you don't mean. It's about the fact that positivity is contagious. Customers can feel it within seconds of meeting you. When you walk up with real energy, you change the emotional temperature of the interaction before you have asked a single discovery question. And here's the part that surprises a lot of new salespeople: attitude can outperform knowledge. I've seen consultants who barely understood the product still close deals because customers wanted to buy from them. I've also seen product experts, people who could recite every spec on the lot, fail completely because their attitude pushed customers away. Knowledge without attitude will lose to attitude without knowledge, almost every time.

Use your big smile energy!

THE SECOND LAYER: GRATITUDE

This is one that people skip past, but it's foundational. I show up every day genuinely thankful for the opportunity to help people solve a real problem- getting them into a vehicle that fits their life. That's not a script line. It's a mindset shift. When you see your job as a favor you're doing for someone rather than a transaction you're extracting from them, your entire tone changes. Customers pick up on that difference immediately, and it's one they can't quite articulate, but they feel it.

Shift your mindset to being thankful to help someone solve a real problem.

THE THIRD LAYER: THE MINDSET OF A WINNER

Having the mindset of a winner means that you show up each day expecting to win. And then you work at it like you expect to win. You are not hoping, you are not wishing, you are **expecting** to win. That expectation shapes how you greet your first customer, how you handle your fifth “no” of the day, and how you carry yourself when the floor is slow. Winners don’t wait for the right customer to show up before they turn on their energy. They bring the energy first, every time, and let the results follow.

Expect to win. Work to win.

THE THREE LAYERS= ATTITUDE IS THE FOUNDATION

The three layers together, add up to a principle: Attitude sets the foundation, but it doesn’t replace the process. A great attitude with zero product knowledge can still produce a sale. Deep product knowledge paired with a poor attitude will still produce a failure. Attitude is the multiplier. The ten steps we are working through together are the mechanics. Without the right attitude behind them, those mechanics fall flat.

So before you ever get to a greeting, a discovery question, or a walkaround, ask yourself three things every single morning:

1. Am I bringing positive energy that customers will feel?
2. Am I genuinely grateful for this opportunity?
3. Am I showing up today expecting to win?

Getting your attitude right with these questions forms the emotional foundation for everything in this program.

STEP 2

The Power Meet & Greet

The Power Meet & Greet is where your attitude meets your first words to a customer. In the last chapter, we talked about attitude- the foundation everything else gets built on.

How you open the interaction sets the tone for everything that follows. Now it's time to put that attitude to work in the first ten seconds that a customer sees you. This is a simple concept that can be easily missed or not taken as seriously as it should be.

THE POWER MEET & GREET:

Let's talk about what most salespeople do.

They walk up and say, "Are you here for sales or service?" or, "Can I help you find someone?" There is nothing wrong with those questions on the surface. But here's the problem: they're common. They are expected. And anything common triggers a negative emotional response in a customer who has heard that exact line a hundred times at a hundred other dealerships or stores.

The moment that you sound like everyone else, you get filed into the same category as everyone else- the pushy salesperson they've been trained to avoid.

So we don't do common. We do a pattern interrupt. A pattern interrupt is exactly what it sounds like- you say something the customer has never heard before, and it breaks whatever script they were running in their head. Most people walk onto a lot with their guard already up. **They've rehearsed how they're going to brush you off.** A pattern interrupt takes that rehearsed defense and makes it useless, because it doesn't match anything they prepared for.

EXAMPLE:

Sales: Welcome to ABC Motors. My name is Curtis----and you are?"

Customer: Hi. My name is Sam.

Sales: Good to meet you, Sam! First off, I just want to thank you for giving me the opportunity to work with you today. My goal is to provide you with world-class service. Before we get started, can I get you something to drink?

Let's break down why every single line matters:

- Introducing myself and asking their name immediately makes this personal instead of transactional.
- Thanking them for the opportunity does something most salespeople never think to do- it flips the power dynamic. I'm not asking for their business. I'm acknowledging they've already given me something of value: their time and attention.
- Stating my goal out loud- world class service- plants an expectation. Now I'm accountable to a standard that I set for myself.
- When offering a drink, 9 times out of 10, they'll say "no thanks." That's fine. That's not the point. The point is you just did something unexpected, over-the-top friendly, and dripping with genuine customer service. Whatever plan that customer walked in with to deflect you just evaporated.

KEY TAKEAWAY:

You don't get a second chance to make this first impression. You don't save this for customers who "seem nice". You run this exact greeting, every single time, with everyone who walks onto the lot.

LET'S DO A QUICK ASSESSMENT

QUESTION: "What exactly makes the Power Meet & Greet effective?"

Option A: Using a memorized, word-for-word script every time.

Option B: Show genuine warmth. **(Correct)**

KEY TAKEAWAYS:

The words matter less than you might think. If you say it flat and robotic, it's just another script and the customer's guard stays up.

The sincerity and surprise of finding genuine warmth is what works. Say it like you mean it, every single time.

STEP 3

Discovery: Uncovering Wants, Needs & Budget

You've got Step 1, Attitude, and Step 2, the Power Meet & Greet in your tool kit. Next, we move to Step 3, Discovery, where I'll show you exactly how to uncover who your customer is, what they really want, and what they can spend, all in one smooth conversation.

By the time you get to the write-up, the deal is already decided. What you offer, how you negotiate, even whether you hit your gross- all of that gets determined here, in discovery. Step 3 is where you gather the ammunition you'll use for the rest of the sale.

IDENTIFYING BUYER & TIMELINE:

First thing: I don't do small talk. None. Zero.

Social media has conditioned every customer walking onto your lot to expect value instantly. They're used to swiping past anything that doesn't grab them in the first two seconds. If you spend the first five minutes talking about the weather or asking how their day is going, you've already lost momentum. Worse- you look like every other salesperson they've ever dealt with.

Instead, I move straight into value. I start finding out who the vehicle is for, what they want, what they need, and what they can spend- all inside a natural, smooth conversation. No interrogation. No clipboard. Just a conversation with a purpose.

That purpose is simple: everything I ask has two jobs. It gathers information, and it sets up something I will use later- in the walkaround, in the demo, or at the negotiating table. I'm going to hand you the exact questions I use to identify the buyer, gauge their timeline, dig into emotional value, and land on a real budget number- without ever asking about a down payment directly.

Get this step right, and everything gets easier downstream. Get it wrong, and you will be selling blind for the rest of the deal.

That's the mindset, now let's build the skill.

We've already established that discovery isn't small talk, it's targeted conversation with a purpose. I want to break down the first two questions I ask every single customer, and show you why each one is doing more work than it sounds like on the surface.

KEY TAKEAWAY:

Discovery is a targeted conversation with a purpose. It should be natural, and smooth. It is not an interrogation.

QUESTION #1:

Sales: (While walking toward the lot)
So, who's the lucky one getting a new car?

Even if there's only one person standing in front of me, I still ask it that way. Why? Because this question serves two purposes. On the surface, it identifies my buyer- who is actually making this decision today. But underneath that, it locks them in. Once someone answers "me", they've just claimed ownership of this decision out loud. That matters later, because if negotiations get tense, a customer can't turn around and say, "well, this is really for my husband," or "I need to check with someone else." They already told you who it's for. You removed that exit before they ever needed it.

Every question in discovery has a dual purpose. There is what you are asking, and there is what you are really accomplishing. Keep that in mind, because it will show up again.

Once I know who the buyer is, I follow up with congratulations. Then I ask the second question.

QUESTION #2:

Sales: How long have you been thinking about getting a new car or truck?

On the surface, this sounds like polite curiosity. It's not. This question is a diagnostic tool. The average buyer shops for about two weeks before they make a purchase. So when a customer answers, I now have a benchmark. If they say "about two weeks", I know they're right in the normal buying window- informed, ready, and not just browsing.

But here's the real value: this question also protects you later in the process. If a customer starts pumping the brakes near the end and says, "I just started looking, I'm not ready to decide," you already have their own words on record. They told you at the start that they had been shopping for two weeks. That objection doesn't hold up, because you asked the timeline early, before there was any pressure attached to the answer.

That's the pattern again. Surface question: how long have you been shopping? Real function: gauge urgency and remove a future stall before it even happens.

Notice what is happening in both of these moves. You're not interrogating your customer. You're having a smooth, natural conversation, but every question is doing double duty. One layer serves the conversation. The other layer serves you three steps down the road, when emotions are higher and objections start surfacing.

This is the discipline of discovery. You're not just collecting information. You're building the foundation that makes the rest of the sale easier, identifying your real decision-maker, and establishing their urgency, all before you've shown them a single vehicle.

UNCOVERING VALUE WITH THE POWER OF WHY:

Now we move to the question that changes everything: "What is it about this one that jumped out to you?" I ask this after I know who the vehicle is for and how long they've been shopping. Their answer is never just one thing. It's a blend. Some of what they tell you are "wants", some are "needs." Your job right now is to listen for both. Don't just nod and move on. This is the moment you're gathering ammunition.

Here's why that matters. Most salespeople hear "I want a 4X4" and think, "Great. Check the box, move to the next feature." That's a mistake. A feature by itself has no emotional weight. It's just a spec on a sheet. But behind every feature is a reason- and that reason is where your leverage lives. So when a customer tells you the 4X4 is a must, you don't move on. You ask why.

I'll say it exactly like this:

Sales: Now you said the 4X4 is a must. Can I ask why that is so important?

And here's a real answer I've gotten on my own floor:

Customer: I like to take my kids to the snow every year, so we need it for that.

Stop and notice what just happened. Thirty seconds ago this was a feature preference. Now it's an emotional commitment. That customer isn't picturing a drivetrain anymore. They're picturing their kids in the snow, laughing, safe, having a great day- because of the vehicle you are about to sell them.

That single word "why" did all of that work.

Emotions sell. Features are logical. Logic gets compared, negotiated, and talked out of. Emotion gets bought. Every "why" you ask converts a checklist item into a personal story, and personal stories are what customers defend later, even to themselves.

Here's the part that separates a good salesperson from a great one: They don't just collect that story and forget it. They bank it. That 4X4-and-snow answer is now two things at once. It's a conversation piece- something you can bring up naturally on the demo drive to build rapport. And it's a closing tool- something you can return to later if this customer starts wavering on price or features. "Remember, this is the one that gets your kids to the snow safely every year" That line does more work in a negotiation than any spec sheet ever will.

KEY TAKEAWAY:

Every time a customer names a want or a need, don't accept it at face value. Ask why. Listen for the emotion underneath the feature. Then hold onto that answer, because you will use it again- on the drive, at the desk, and at the close. Step 3 is not about collecting facts, it's about collecting leverage, one honest "why" at a time. This is why Step 3 is where the money is made.

RECAPPING AND ASKING THE BUDGET QUESTION:

So far in Step 3, we've identified our buyer, found the timeline, and dug into the "why" behind what they want. Now it's time to bring it all together with one of the most underrated moves in the entire process: the recap. And right behind it, the question every rookie dreads and every pro handles with ease- the budget question.

Let's get into it.

Here's the thing about recapping. By this point in the conversation, you've collected a handful of details- color preference, number of doors, the 4X4 requirement, maybe a comment about fuel economy. Most sales people move on to the next step. That's a mistake. Before you go anywhere, recap what you've heard.

A recap does something powerful psychologically. It proves that you were actually listening. Customers are used to being talked at, not listened to. When you play their own words back to them, you separate yourself immediately, and you build trust fast.

Here's how it sounds in practice:

Sales: Mr. Customer, just to confirm- you like the color- this is the exact color you want. You need the four-door for the family, you need the 4X4 for the trips, but you don't want a V8 because of the fuel mileage. It looks like you picked out a good one.

Notice what just happened. You didn't invent anything new. You handed back exactly what they told you, organized and confirmed. That builds massive rapport in about ten seconds.

Now, and this is the important part, that recap isn't just a trust-builder. It's a setup. Because the moment you finish confirming their wants and needs, you flow directly into the budget question. No pause, no awkward pivot.

It sounds like this:

Sales: ... and if this one works out, what monthly budget have you set aside for this?

That's it. One smooth sentence. The recap did the heavy lifting. The customer feels heard, they are nodding along, and the budget question lands as a natural next step in the conversation instead of an interrogation.

Let's say they respond with five hundred dollars a month, now what?

This is where you need a rule of thumb. Most customers have no idea what that monthly number actually translates to in terms of what they can finance. My rule is simple: twenty to twenty-five dollars per thousand dollars financed. So if a customer tells you five hundred a month, you're looking at roughly twenty to twenty-five thousand dollars financed, depending on rate and term.

Never ask about a down payment directly. Never. This tends to trip up new salespeople. Here's why. If you ask "how much are you putting down?" you put the customer on the defensive. It feels like a qualifying question, and it makes them guarded. Instead, I assume zero down and land my numbers accordingly.

If they actually do have a down payment, they will tell you. Almost every time. Customers volunteer that information naturally once they feel comfortable, especially after a recap where you've already shown them you are listening and on their side. You don't need to extract it. You just need to create the space for them to offer it.

One more strategy: if your numbers, based on their monthly budget, are running higher than what you're showing them, that's your cue to suggest something less expensive and let them upgrade themselves. If your numbers are right in line, you simply continue forward. Either way, you're never guessing. You're calculating.

KEY TAKEAWAYS:

- **Recap before you ask about budget.**
- **Use the \$20 to \$25 per \$1000 rule to gauge affordability.**
- **Never ask about a down payment directly.**
- **Master this sequence** so that budget conversation becomes the natural next sentence in a conversation where the customer already feels understood.

STEP 4

Vehicle Selection & Presentation

You've got Step 3 fully locked in. The recap earns trust, the budget question turns conversations into numbers, and the rule of thumb keeps you working in the right range from the start.

Now we move to Step 4. We move into Walk and Choose, where we start turning all this discovery into an actual vehicle in front of your customer.

Our current reality, thanks to the internet, is that most customers already know exactly what they want before they ever step on your lot. They've done the research. They've read the reviews. They've picked the trim level. So my job during Walk & Choose isn't to talk them in to something else. My job is to set up leverage that I'll use later.

Here's how: the Curveball Setup. Even when a customer knows precisely what they want, I'll still say something like this: "Can I throw you a curveball?" Customer says "sure." Then I say, "If I have one that's slightly older, with a few more miles, but a little less expensive, would you want to see it?"

Nine times out of ten, they will say no. And that's exactly the answer I want.

Think about what just happened.

I didn't lose anything by asking. But I planted a seed. Later, in negotiation, if that customer pushes back on price, I have a ready-made answer: "Remember that other option I mentioned? We could look at that one instead." I'm not scrambling for a discount in the moment. I already pre-built one, and the customer opted out of it themselves. That makes it their decision, not a concession I'm handing over.

KEY TAKEAWAYS:

- **It's not really about choosing a vehicle.** It's about quietly installing a fallback position before you ever need it.
- **Mention the cheaper option,** expect the decline, and file that decline away for later. It costs you nothing, and it saves you gross profit down the road.
- **Even confident, internet-informed buyers benefit from the curveball question.** The expected answer is "no."
- **The expected "no" becomes your quiet leverage** when pricing conversations get tough later in the deal.
- **Get comfortable asking this question every time, regardless of how sure the customer seems.** It takes ten seconds, it costs you nothing.
- **If you skip asking,** you walk into negotiation with one less tool in your pocket.

STEP 5

Displaying The Vehicle

In Step 4 you learned to get comfortable with the Curveball Setup, that moment during the Walk & Choose step where you offer a customer something less expensive right before they have locked onto the vehicle they really want. You now have your quiet leverage tool in your pocket for later negotiations.

Once the customer has chosen, or confirmed their choice, you're ready to move into Step 5, where we display the vehicle and start building real emotional momentum.

When we display the vehicle is the moment where emotions genuinely start to shift. Your customer begins, often without realizing it, to take psychological ownership of the vehicle.

The main principle behind Step 5 is to isolate the vehicle. One car. Full focus. No distractions.

I always identify a spot that is shaded and protected from the weather. Then I ask my customer to wait there while I pull the vehicle around myself.

There are two deliberate reasons for this.

First, if your customer is left standing in an open lot while you go retrieve keys, what happens? They wander. They start eyeing other vehicles. Maybe a competing model catches their attention, or worse, they start second-guessing the choice they made in Step 4.

Second, this gives me a private window to prepare the vehicle before they ever step inside it. I'll pull it up, and depending on the weather, I'll get the air conditioning or the heat running. That way, when my customer opens that door, they're not met with a blast of heat or cold. They are stepping into comfort. That small detail signals something bigger: I thought about you before you even got here.

This is where emotional buy-in starts to build. The customer isn't just looking at a car anymore, they are beginning to picture themselves in it. Your job in this step is simple: protect that focus, and remove every small friction point before it has a chance to interrupt the moment.

Get this step right, and you've set the stage perfectly for Step 6, where we walk the vehicle and sell specifically to what matters most to your customer.

KEY TAKEAWAYS:

- **Step 5 is two moves:** isolate the car, and prepare the experience before they ever get inside the vehicle. It sounds small. It isn't.
- **Skip this step and you risk losing focus and momentum** right when the customer's emotional engagement is starting to build.
- **Nail it, and you've locked their attention on exactly one vehicle-** the one you're about to sell them.

STEP 6

Selling The Walkaround

In Step 6, Selling The Walkaround, you'll learn to present only what matters to your customer. You can't afford to exhaust their patience.

You will be using six categories to assess the customer's cues: style, comfort, safety, performance, utility, and economy.

You've picked out the vehicle in Step 4, and you've displayed it in Step 5. The car is isolated, comfortable, ready to go. Emotions are starting to build. This is where a lot of salespeople make their first real mistake. They walk up to that vehicle and start rattling off every single feature it has. Sunroof, cupholders, USB ports, tire pressure sensors- all of it, whether the customer cares or not.

Here's the problem. The customer is impatient. Everyone is these days. If you start talking about something they don't value, you lose them fast. So before I say one word about the vehicle, I do something different, I grab myself a map.

I ask the customer directly: "What would you like me to go over?" There are a lot of cool features on this vehicle, but I don't want to bore you with the stuff that is not important to you." That question does two things. It respects their time, and it hands me the exact roadmap I need to close this step efficiently.

Whatever they tell me, I group the information into one of six categories:

- 1. Style-** how it looks, the color, the trim level
- 2. Comfort-** seating, interior space, climate features
- 3. Safety-** airbags, blind spot monitoring, camera systems
- 4. Performance-** engine, handling, towing capacity
- 5. Utility-** cargo space, seating configuration, third row.
- 6. Economy-** fuel efficiency, maintenance costs, resale value

Remember our customer from Step 3 who told us the 4x4 was a must because of family snow trips? That's not just a want- that is Utility and Safety talking. So when we get to the Walkaround, that is exactly where I spend my time. I'm not selling the sound system to a person who never mentioned it. I'm selling the 4X4 capability, the ground clearance, maybe the all-weather traction. I'm selling what they already told me mattered.

This is the discipline part. You might personally love talking about horsepower, but if your customer only flagged Comfort and Economy, that's where you live. Anything else is noise, and noise costs you the sale.

KEY TAKEAWAYS:

- **Before you say a single word about the vehicle, ask what matters to them.** Sort their answer into Style, Comfort, Safety, Performance, Utility, or Economy. Then sell only those categories and sell them well.
- **Skip the rest.** Every feature you mention that they don't care about is a withdrawal from their patience. And patience is the one thing you can't afford to overspend in this step.



Notes:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are approximately 20 lines visible. The paper has a slightly aged or off-white appearance.

STEP 7

The Demo Drive

You've walked the customer through the vehicle, you've sold the features that actually matter to them. Now we are ready for Step 7, the demo drive.

This is the step where everything changes.

Up until now, the customer has been curious, maybe even relaxed. But the second they think about actually getting behind the wheel, real emotion kicks in. Master this step, and you'll never let a customer talk themselves out of the most important five minutes of the sale, the demo drive.

Here's the psychology you need to understand: strong emotion makes people defensive. That's not a coincidence, it's human nature. When people feel something intensely, their guard goes up, and they look for an exit.

That is exactly why the test drive is the step customers try hardest to skip. You'll hear it constantly.

- “I don't need to drive it, I've driven this model before.
- “I trust you, let's just talk numbers.”
- “I'm short on time today.”

None of these are real objections. They are emotional exits. The customer isn't avoiding a car ride, they are avoiding the moment where this becomes real.

Your job is not to argue with them. Your job is to give them a genuine benefit-driven reason to get in that car.

Notice I said “benefit-driven” NOT “pressure-driven.” This isn't about insisting. It's about connecting the drive back to something they already told you matters.

Remember discovery in Step 3? You already know their wants, their needs, the emotional trigger behind this purchase. Use it. If they mentioned smooth handling, you might say, “You mentioned comfort on long drives. This is really something you feel, not something I can describe. Let's give you five minutes behind the wheel.” If safety came up, connect the drive to that. The reason has to be theirs, not yours.

The deeper reason why this step cannot be skipped is that the test drive is where ownership starts forming emotionally. A customer who has only seen the car is still a shopper. a customer who has driven it is starting to picture it in their driveway. That shift in identity, from shopper to owner, is worth more to the sale than any spec sheet. Skip the drive, and you skip that shift. So hold your ground here, professionally and warmly. Give them the benefit, not the argument, and get them in the seat.

Once you are moving, something interesting happens. The emotional intensity that made them defensive becomes an opening. That tension starts to ease the moment the wheels start turning, and that's exactly where rapport-building comes in. We will cover that in the next chapter.

Before we move on to Step 8, let's take a moment with a practice question. It will help you recognize patterns in the moment, not just in theory.

EXAMPLE:

Here's the scenario. You've displayed the vehicle, you've walked around it, and now it's time to drive.

Customer: Honestly, I don't need to drive it. I already know I like it. Can we just skip to the numbers?

This is the guard going up. Their emotions are rising, and some part of them wants to protect against getting too attached, or too pressured. Your job isn't to argue. It isn't to insist. It's to give them a reason, framed around their benefit, for why the drive matters.



Notes:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins or other markings on the paper.

STEP 8

Building Rapport On The Drive

By this point in the process, your customer has committed to the test drive. Emotions are active, guard is coming down, and you have a short window of time to turn a quiet evaluation into a genuine conversation.

Let's talk about how to have that genuine conversation, and why it matters. The rapport you build in this step is the emotional bridge into Step 9, Committing To Come Inside.

A silent test drive feels like a job interview.

The customer is analyzing engine noise, seat comfort, and whether they make the right call walking into your dealership. That's mental work, and mental work creates distance between you and them. Your job in Step 8 is to close that distance.

The technique is simple, almost disarmingly so.

Once you're rolling, ask something personal and low-pressure. Try something like, "By the way, I never asked. What type of work do you do?" Then follow their answer with genuine curiosity. "Oh really? How did you get into that?"

Notice what's happening. You're not selling.

You're not pointing out lumbar support. You're having the kind of conversation two people have when they actually like each other. That's the entire point. You want this drive to feel like two buddies talking, not a formal evaluation with a salesperson grading their reactions.

Why does this matter for the sale? Because rapport is the emotional bridge into Step 9 Committing To Come Inside. A relaxed customer who feels comfortable with you is far more likely to say yes to walking into the showroom. A tense customer who felt interrogated the entire drive is looking for the nearest exit the second you park.

KEY TAKEAWAY:

Rapport isn't small talk for the sake of small talk. It is a deliberate move to keep the customer relaxed and emotionally engaged before heading inside.



Notes:

STEP 9

Committing to Come Inside

You just finished the test drive and started building rapport, turning a test drive into a real conversation.

Don't fumble the handoff. Salespeople can tend to allow an awkward silence when they go into the dealership, or worse, scramble for their business card like they just met the customer. That gap is where deals die. In this chapter, I give you the exact script I use to lock in the next step before we even reach the driveway.

Here's the psychology. The peak of a customer's emotion isn't when you are parked back at the dealership. It is during the drive, right now, when they are behind the wheel, feeling the vehicle, picturing it in their driveway. If you wait until you are back on the lot to bring up next steps, you've let that emotional peak cool off. So we set the commitment up early, about a quarter mile before the driveway, while the customer is still riding that high.

Here is exactly how it goes:

Sales: (As you are getting close) So what do you think of the drive?

Customer: (Almost every time) I like it.

That's your opening. You follow up with:

Sales: I'll tell you what. When we get back, I'll show you what it takes to own it, and you can tell me yes, no, or that you want time to think about it. I'm okay with any of the three. Fair enough?

Read that again, because every word is doing work for you. You are not asking permission to come inside, you are already assuming it. You're just framing what happens once you are inside. And notice the three outcomes you offer: yes, no, or you need time to think. That's the key. You are handing them an exit before they even need one.

Why does that matter psychologically? Because fear of being trapped is the number one reason customers avoid walking into a showroom. They've all had the experience of getting cornered at a desk, and their guard goes up the second they think that might be happening again. When you tell them up front "no is a completely fine answer", you disarm that fear before it even shows up. There is nothing for them to resist because you've already told them they're not obligated.

The customer says “yes” to coming inside, not because you pressured them, but because you removed the pressure. You gave them control, and people walk toward things that feel safe, not away from them.

One more thing worth noting: timing is everything here. Say this too early and it feels disconnected from the moment. Say it too late, after you've already parked, and you've lost the emotional window. Now it feels like a sales tactic instead of a natural next step. A quarter mile out, mid-conversation, riding on the momentum of "I like it" is the sweet spot.

KEY TAKEAWAYS:

- **You are not just filling silence on the way back to the lot.** You are engineering the moment so the customer walks inside feeling like it was their idea, not yours.
- **Never let the drive back to the dealership go quiet.** Ask about the drive, offer the three options, and lock in that next step when emotion is still working in your favor.
- **Practice this script until it feels natural.** The timing has to feel natural, not rehearsed.



Notes:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins or other markings on the paper.

STEP 10

The Write Up & Close

By this point, your customer has driven the vehicle, you have built real rapport, and you have already secured their commitment to come inside. What you do in the next few minutes determines whether all that work pays off.

Speed is everything at this stage. We will explore that principle in practice in this chapter. I want you to have this momentum locked in to your technique.

Every dealership has its own write-up process. Some use a desk log, some use a manager's office, some run numbers digitally. I cover my exact process in Book 3 of this series, *The First Five*. But regardless of the paper workflow at your store, the psychology influencing it never changes.

Think about where your customer is emotionally right now. They just came from the demo drive. Their excitement is at its peak. They can picture themselves owning this vehicle. That emotional high is exactly what caused them to say yes to coming inside in the first place.

Emotion is perishable. It doesn't hold. The moment you sit them down and start with small talk, or you disappear for ten minutes looking for a manager, or you fumble around getting pencil to paper, that emotion starts leaking out of the room. And it doesn't come back on its own.

Protect the emotion, and you protect the deal. The direct cost of dragging your feet is losing gross profit. The longer it takes to get an offer in front of your customer, the more emotion you lose, and the more gross profit you lose right alongside it. Those two things move

KEY TAKEAWAYS:

- **The excitement is doing the selling for you.** Keep the energy up. Don't lose focus to anything else.
- **Get the information you need, move it into process fast, and get a number in front of your customer while that excitement is still fresh.** No extended chit-chat while you're at the desk. No wandering off to handle something else "real quick."
- **Paperwork policy varies by store, but that's not as important as the psychological reason we need to move fast.** It's about utilizing the emotion before it fades.

Summary

We have walked through all the steps of the sale, from the moment you shake a customer's hand to the moment you hand them the keys. You now have all ten steps and an understanding of the significance of each step. Each step has a specific job to do, and each one sets up the step that follows it.

Now it's time to bring it all together. Understanding each step individually isn't the same as understanding why the sequence works. In this chapter, I will show you why each step exists, and why skipping one costs you more than you think.

Step 3 is where the deal actually gets made.

Not step 10. This is a truth that I would like to see embedded in your brain. Everybody wants to rush to the write-up. That is where the paper-work happens, so it feels like the finish line. But the write-up only works because of what you uncovered back in discovery, who the vehicle is for, what they want, what they need, and what budget they've set aside. Step 10 is just where you cash the check that Step 3 wrote.

Customers will try to get you to skip steps.

This is something you need to prepare for.

They will tell you they don't need the vehicle displayed. They will tell you they don't need a test drive. They are not doing this to be difficult! They are trying to manage their own emotions, because every step that builds value also builds pressure to decide.

You need a customer benefit reason for every single step you take. Not a script reason. Not a policy reason. A reason that benefits them. If they push back on the demo drive, you don't say "it's our process." You give them a reason that serves their decision, because a test drive is where they confirm that this is the right choice, not just the right price.

KEY TAKEAWAYS OF THE 10 STEP SALE:

- **Attitude** sets the tone.
- **The Power Meet & Greet** earns you a real shot instead of getting lumped in with every generic salesperson they have brushed off before.
- **Discovery** hands you the leverage and the budget.
- **Walk & Choose** plants a seed for later negotiation. display creates ownership before they have even sat in the driver's seat.
- **The six category Walkaround** keeps you talking about what they actually care about instead of rambling.
- **The Demo Drive** is where emotion peaks. Rapport turns that drive into a relationship instead of a transaction.
- **Pre-committment** removes the fear of walking back inside.
- **The Write Up** captures the value you built, fast, before the emotion cools off.

Congratulations on completing the 10 Step Sale!

Every step feeds the next one. Skip one, and you weaken the step that follows it.

Learn to recognize that sometimes moving forward means going backward first. If a customer stalls at the Write Up, that's usually not a Step 10 problem. That is a sign that you need to circle back. Maybe there is a detail from Discovery that you missed, or a benefit from the Walkaround that never landed properly. Taking a step backward isn't failure. It's precision.



Notes:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are approximately 20 lines visible. The paper has a slightly aged or off-white appearance.

[illegible]This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

About the Author

Curtis Rigglesman is a successful Director of Operations who currently manages several dealerships in Central California. He came from a background of poverty. Through determination and a winning attitude, he made his way to the top of his field. His passion is to empower new salesmen and sales managers to confidently engage customers and level up their income.



Level Up:

Check out the other books in the series

1. Dial For Dollars

2.Objections Aren't Real

3. The First Five Sales

4. Built To Lead

5. Closing 101

6. The Road To The Sale



Notes:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are approximately 20 lines visible. The paper has a slightly aged or off-white appearance.

THE ROAD TO THE SALE: Attitude is contagious- and so is a bad first impression. I'll show you why most greetings fail before they start, and how one pattern-interrupt move -the Power Meet & Greet changes everything. Ready to stop sounding like everyone else on the floor? Let's get started.

LEVEL UP:

- Build a winning mindset.
- Learn the nuances of the 10 step sale.
- Learn the exact words that make customers drop their guard.
- Get to yes with your customers, with less wear and tear on everyone involved.



L Meredith
Publishing

